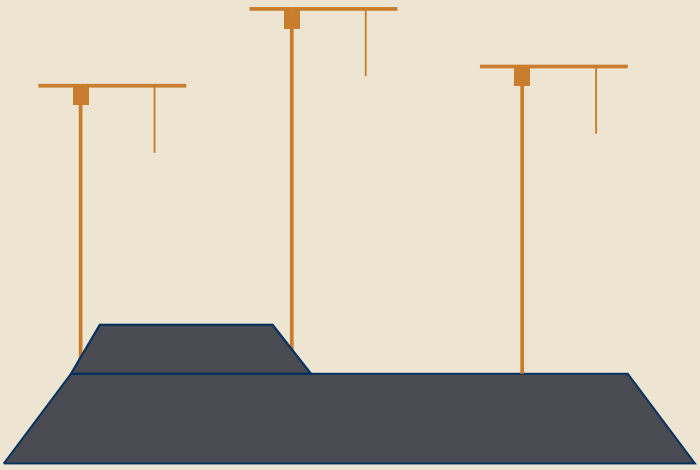


B A R C E L O N A

A Humanized Walking Tour

Més que un club

A Walking Tour of Spotify Camp Nou

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11 tracks · word-for-word narration script

The Barça Immersive Tour and the Construction Viewpoint

“El Barça no és un club, és un sentiment.”

— Barça is not a club, it is a feeling —

Manuel Vázquez Montalbán, 1972 · Catalan novelist and Barça partisan

V4 · Humanized pacing edition · English narration

Tour Roadmap

11 tracks · approximately 70 minutes of word-for-word narration

Track 00 · Welcome and Navigation Guide — Before you walk in · How to use this tour **· 4 min**

Track 01 · The Gates of Les Corts — Outside · The cranes, the dust, and the scale of Espai Barça **· 5 min**

Track 02 · Més que un club — Inside · Sunyol, the language, and a club that became a country **· 8 min**

Track 03 · The Silverware — Inside · Wembley 1992 and the five European nights **· 6 min**

Track 04 · Cruyff — Inside · The Dutchman who taught a club how to think **· 9 min**

Track 05 · La Masia — Inside · The 1702 farmhouse and the boys it raised **· 6 min**

Track 06 · Messi — Inside · The napkin, the 672 goals, and the day he left **· 9 min**

Track 07 · The 360 Degree Room — Inside · 99,000 voices, in a stadium that no longer exists **· 6 min**

Track 08 · The Construction Viewpoint — Outside · The bowl, the cranes, and what comes next **· 7 min**

Track 09 · The Model — Inside · The finished stadium, scaled to your hand **· 5 min**

Track 10 · Outside Again — Conclusion · The motto returned **· 5 min**

This script is the companion to the audio recordings. Each track is written word-for-word in the voice of a passionate friend walking Barcelona with you. Em-dashes signal short breath beats. Ellipses signal longer reflective pauses. Follow the navigation cues at the start of each track before pressing play. The entrance is the former ice rink on Carrer d'Arístides Maillol, not the main stadium gate — the stadium itself is closed for reconstruction. Take Camp Nou slowly. You are walking a building in the middle of becoming itself.

Track 00 · Welcome and Navigation Guide

Before you walk in · How to use this tour

4 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Anywhere convenient before you enter — on the metro, in a café, or walking up from the Palau Reial station. You don't need to be at the stadium yet. The entrance you're looking for is the former ice rink, on the south side of the complex, off Carrer d'Arístides Maillol — not the main stadium gate. The stadium itself is closed.

Welcome to Barcelona. And welcome to Camp Nou — or what's left of it, and what's rising in its place.

This is the largest football stadium in Europe. Or it was, before they started taking it apart in June 2023. Right now, in 2026, you're visiting a building site — a 1957 concrete bowl with its roof off and its third tier half-demolished, while a 105,000-seat stadium is rebuilt around the empty pitch. The team plays here at reduced capacity. The traditional stadium tour — down the tunnel, into the dressing room, out to the grass, the photograph beside the manager's bench — doesn't exist anymore. If you've seen photos from a friend's 2019 visit, set those aside. The stadium experience you've already booked is a different and, honestly, stranger thing. A building in the middle of becoming itself.

What exists today is the Barça Immersive Tour — a temporary museum in the former ice rink next door. Eighteen rooms. A 360-degree video chamber. And a viewing deck pointed straight into the construction site. That's what we're going to walk together.

Finding the right entrance

First thing. People get lost here. The complex is large and the signage still points at parts of the old stadium that no longer function. So walk toward the south side, along Carrer d'Arístides Maillol. You're looking for the low building marked Barça Immersive Tour or FCB Museum. It used to be the Palau de Gel — the ice rink. Not the main stadium gate. Not the megastore door, which is the exit. The ice rink is where you go in.

If you find yourself standing in front of a tall stadium façade with no obvious entrance, you've drifted too far north. Turn around and walk south until you see the queue under a glass canopy. That's it.

A one-way route

Now, an important thing about how this museum is laid out. The route is one-directional. Once you pass through the 360-degree immersive room, two-thirds of the way through, you cannot go back. The doors behind you lock. So if there's something you want a second look at — the napkin Messi was signed on, the Ballons d'Or, the Cruyff jersey, the women's team display — take that second look the first time. You won't get another chance without buying a new ticket.

Where to linger, where to move

A few hard-earned tips from people who've done this. Most visitors spend three-quarters of their time in the first few rooms — the entry video, the trophy gallery, the Cruyff space — and then rush the construction viewpoint at the end. Don't do that. The construction viewpoint is the single most unusual thing in this complex right now, and it will not exist a year from now. Give it ten full minutes. Two minutes of looking; eight minutes of letting your eye actually settle into the scale of what you're seeing.

Two specific things people miss. The Sunyol monument — a small memorial to the club's president executed during the Civil War — sits outside the museum building, on the perimeter walk. We'll talk about him in Track Two. After the tour, walk the outer ring and find him. And the napkin Messi was first contracted on. It's in a small display case in the Messi room and most people walk past it. We'll point to it when we get there.

Practical bits

Layers. The immersive rooms are kept cold for the projectors; the construction viewpoint is outdoor and exposed. You'll want a thin jacket on hand. Photography is fine almost everywhere; the two exceptions are the 360-degree room itself (during the show) and the Espai Barça model gallery, where flash isn't allowed because of the lighting design. Headphones aren't required — you're listening to me — but if you have a pair, the immersive room sound mix is noticeably better with them in.

One real warning. The 360-degree immersive room has strong, fast, strobing light effects — long sequences, bright pulses. If you have epilepsy or any photo-sensitivity, skip it. There's a bypass corridor and the stewards know to wave you around. Don't be shy about asking.

How long this takes

The narration on this tour runs about 70 minutes. Add walking, stopping, looking, the inevitable shop browse at the end, and you'll spend about two hours in here. Eleven tracks. The first is outside, before you go in. The last is at the megastore exit, in the Barcelona sun.

When you’re ready, walk to the security perimeter on Carrer d’Arístides Maillol. Stand outside the chain-link fence. Look up at the cranes. And let Track One begin.

Track 01 · The Gates of Les Corts

Outside · The cranes, the dust, and the scale of Espai Barça

5 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Stand on the sidewalk of Carrer d’Arístides Maillol, just outside the security fencing. Look up. The bowl is in front of you. The cranes rise above it. The Barça Immersive Tour entrance is to your left, in the low building that used to be the Palau de Gel — the ice rink.

Stop here. Look up.

What you’re seeing isn’t a stadium. Not yet. It’s a stadium being rebuilt around its own bones. The bowl in front of you opened on the 24th of September 1957. For 66 years it stood essentially the same shape — a deep, oval concrete crater, three tiers, the largest seating capacity in Europe. Then, on the 1st of June 2023, the demolition started.

Look at the third tier. Look at the top ring of seats. It’s gone. The entire upper rim of the stadium has been taken down. Where you can see raw concrete edges and exposed steel — that’s the cut. The cranes you’re looking at are putting the new third tier back, taller and wider, with the final capacity set at 105,000 seats. When the stadium opens fully, it will be the largest in Europe again. By a long way.

What you’re actually looking at

This project is called Espai Barça. The total budget started around 1.5 billion euros and has climbed since. The main contractor is a Turkish firm called Limak Holding. The site runs 24 hours a day, three shifts, every day of the week. You’re hearing some of that now — the rumble of diesel engines, the high beep of reversing trucks, the clang of steel.

The original reopening was supposed to be November 2024. It slipped to 2025. The team returned to a partially open stadium on the 22nd of November 2025 — four-nil against Athletic Bilbao, with about 45,000 fans in the two open tiers. Capacity has crept up since. The roof — the great tensioned ring that will eventually cover every seat — won’t go on until 2027. So what you’re seeing today is somewhere in the middle. A working construction site that occasionally has a football match in it.

The neighborhood under your feet

Look down. The asphalt here is Les Corts — a working-class district of Barcelona that used to be its own village before the city absorbed it. The stadium’s real name on official paperwork is just Camp Nou. *New field*, in Catalan. Because the previous one — Camp

de Les Corts, just a few streets from here — had become too small for the crowds. The club needed something bigger. They got it.

The sponsor name was added in 2022. Spotify Camp Nou. The Spotify logo now sits on the front of the shirt and on the building. Locals — if you listen to them in the queue for tickets — just call it Camp Nou.

Now walk to the entrance on your left. The Barça Immersive Tour. Through the doors. Through the bag check. Stop in front of the large video wall that opens the exhibition — black-and-white footage, packed terraces, voices in Catalan. That’s where Track Two begins.

Track 02 · Més que un club

Inside · Sunyol, the language, and a club that became a country

8 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

You're inside now. The first room of the Immersive Tour is a large dark space with a long curved video wall showing archive footage — 1920s, 1930s, packed terraces, the old flag of Catalonia. Stand in front of it. Take your time.

Look at the faces on the screen. Black and white, grainy, mostly men in flat caps. The crowd is packed. They're shouting, but you can't hear what. Some of them are dead now. Some of them were killed.

The club's motto is on the wall behind you. *Més que un club.* More than a club. It's the line everyone knows. The slogan on the scarves, the banner unfurled at every home match. But it isn't a marketing line. It was first said out loud by a club president named Narcís de Carreras in 1968, and it meant something specific. It meant that when you have no country, your football team can become one.

Where the club came from

FC Barcelona was founded on the 29th of November 1899, in a gymnasium on Carrer Montjuic del Carme, by eleven men. The founder was a twenty-two-year-old Swiss accountant named Joan Gamper — Hans Gamper at birth, in Winterthur — who had placed a small advertisement in a sports weekly called *Los Deportes* a few weeks earlier. The ad asked anyone interested in playing football to get in touch. Eleven people did. They met at the gymnasium. They voted Gamper president. They chose blue and garnet for the colors. Nobody is sure why — there are theories about a Swiss school crest, theories about the colors of Gamper's hometown, theories that they just liked them.

A Swiss man, in Barcelona, founding a football club for foreigners and locals together. That's the origin. Within a generation, it had become something else.

Why this place is political

Catalonia — the region you're standing in — has its own language, its own flag, its own thousand-year history of being not-quite-Spain. Through the twentieth century, two dictatorships tried to erase that. Primo de Rivera in the 1920s. And then, much more brutally, Francisco Franco from 1939 until his death in 1975. Under Franco, the Catalan language was banned in public. The flag — the senyera, four red stripes on yellow —

was forbidden. Catalan place names were changed. Catalan first names were refused at the civil registry. The Catalan government was abolished. Its president was executed.

And the football stadium — first the old Camp de Les Corts, then this one after 1957 — became one of the only places in the city where you could be Catalan in public. You could speak the language in the stands. You could sing in it. You could shout in it. The regime knew, and didn't intervene, because how do you arrest 90,000 people at once.

So when Barcelona played Real Madrid — the team most associated with the Spanish state and, fairly or not, with Franco himself — it wasn't just football. It was the only legal Catalan demonstration in Spain. That's the context for what people mean when they say *més que un club*. The club was a country in costume.

Josep Sunyol

Now I have to tell you the hardest part of this story, because the man the motto really belongs to is buried in a roadside grave outside Madrid.

His name was Josep Sunyol i Garriga. Born in Barcelona, 1898. Wealthy Catalan family. He was a lawyer, a journalist, a left-wing politician of the Esquerra Republicana, a member of the Spanish parliament, the founder of a sports weekly called *La Rambla* whose slogan was "sport and citizenship". And in 1935, he was elected the twenty-eighth president of FC Barcelona.

He held the office for one year.

In late July 1936, the Spanish Civil War broke out. Sunyol travelled from Barcelona to Madrid — first to Valencia, then on to the besieged Spanish capital — to meet with fellow Republican deputies. On the morning of the 6th of August 1936, he left Madrid in his chauffeur-driven car, flying the Catalan senyera from the bonnet. He drove north, into the Sierra de Guadarrama. The hills above the road were a confusing patchwork of Republican and Franco-aligned positions. Sunyol's car crossed a line without realising it. It was stopped at a checkpoint manned by Falangist troops. He was identified — the senyera on the car gave him away. He was taken out and shot. Without trial. He was thirty-eight years old.

The news took a week to reach Barcelona.

Under Franco, his name was scrubbed. For nearly sixty years the club he led didn't officially mourn him. His body was only exhumed in the 1990s. In 1996, on the sixtieth anniversary of his death, the club held its first formal tribute. In 2003, a corner of this complex was dedicated to him — the Monument a Josep Sunyol. If you walk the perimeter after this tour, you can find it.

He is the reason the motto means what it means.

Sixty years later, a referendum

One more thing before we move. Skip forward to the 1st of October 2017. The Catalan government held an independence referendum that the Spanish state had declared illegal. Spanish national police were sent to Catalonia to stop people voting. They raided polling stations. They beat voters. Hundreds were injured.

That same afternoon, Barcelona were scheduled to play Las Palmas, at this stadium, in front of 90,000 fans. The club asked La Liga to postpone the match. La Liga refused. So the club played the game with the stadium doors locked and the stands empty. The only competitive match at Camp Nou in its history played to no one. The players ran out to silence. The match was streamed live. Lionel Messi scored a hat-trick into an empty bowl.

The empty stadium that day said exactly what the motto says. *Més que un club.*

Now walk left, into the trophy gallery. The lights brighten. The next room is silverware.

Track 03 · The Silverware

Inside · Wembley 1992 and the five European nights

6 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Walk into the long, brightly lit trophy gallery. The display cases run along both walls. Find the line of larger trophies on the right — the Champions League cups, distinctive for their size and the heavy wraparound handles. There are five of them.

You're looking at five replicas. UEFA keeps the originals; every winner gets a copy to put in their museum. But each one represents a night the club won the European Cup. Five nights, scattered across twenty-three years, that rewrote what this team meant in the world.

Wembley, 20th May 1992

Start with the first one. Look at the plaque. London, 1992. Wembley. Final against Sampdoria. The team you're looking at on the photograph below is the Dream Team — Cruyff's side. Stoichkov, Laudrup, Bakero, Guardiola at the base of midfield, Koeman at the back.

The match went to extra time, nil-nil. In the 112th minute, Barça got a free kick about twenty-five yards out. Koeman — the tall Dutch centre-back with a freakishly hard right foot — stepped over the ball. Bakero rolled it sideways. Koeman struck it. The ball flew low, hard, just inside the post. Sampdoria's goalkeeper Pagliuca didn't move.

It was the first European Cup in the club's ninety-three-year history. Until that night, Barcelona were the great loser of European football — five final appearances before 1992, five losses. The Dream Team broke the curse. The party in Barcelona ran for a week. Cruyff said the line he used before every important match. *Salid y disfrutad.* Go out there and enjoy yourselves.

Paris, Rome, Wembley again, Berlin

Now look at the other four. 2006 — Paris, Frank Rijkaard's side, Ronaldinho at his impossible peak, two-one against Arsenal. 2009 — Rome, Pep Guardiola's first year as manager, two-nil against Manchester United, with Eto'o and Messi scoring. 2011 — Wembley again, Guardiola again, three-one against United again, the most complete performance the competition has ever seen. And 2015 — Berlin, Luis Enrique's side, three-one against Juventus, the front three of Messi, Suárez, and Neymar.

Five trophies. Three of them in a span of six years.

And there’s something the men’s display doesn’t mention. The women’s team — the Barça Femí — have won the Champions League three times in the last five years. 2021, 2023, and 2024. Alexia Putellas won the Ballon d’Or Femí in 2021 and 2022. Aitana Bonmatí has won it three times in a row, 2023, 2024, 2025. They are the dominant women’s side in Europe right now, and they’ve done it more recently than any of these men’s cups. The club is slowly giving them more space in the museum. Look for it. It matters.

Now turn the corner. Past the trophy cases. The next room is darker. There’s an orange-and-blue jersey hanging in the centre, lit from above. Number 14.

Track 04 · Cruyff

Inside · The Dutchman who taught a club how to think

9 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Step into the dedicated Cruyff space. There's a display of his jerseys, his quotes lining the walls, archive footage of him as a player and as a manager. Stand in front of the number 14 shirt.

The most important person in the history of this club never grew up here. He grew up across the road from the Ajax stadium in Amsterdam, the son of a greengrocer who died when he was twelve. His name was Hendrik Johannes Cruijff. In English we spelled it Cruyff. He died on the 24th of March 2016, in a hospital in this city, from lung cancer. He had chain-smoked for forty years. He quit and switched to lollipops; the lollipop is on the statue of him outside this complex.

He came to Barcelona twice. First as a player, in 1973. Then as a manager, fifteen years later. The first time he changed the club. The second time he changed football.

The player, 1973

When Cruyff signed from Ajax in August 1973, Barcelona had not won the Spanish league in fourteen years. He cost about two million dollars, a world record at the time. In his first season he won the league — his debut included a five-nil win at the Bernabéu, which the city of Barcelona still talks about. He scored a goal there nobody had ever seen before, where he hooked his leg behind a ball mid-air and redirected it into the net while almost facing away from goal. The papers called it *el gol imposible*. The impossible goal.

He played five seasons here. He led the league in goals. He won the Ballon d'Or in 1973 and 1974. He didn't win another European Cup. But he did something else.

The son named Jordi

In February 1974, his wife gave birth to their third child. Cruyff named the boy Jordi — in Catalan, after the patron saint of Catalonia. Saint George.

Under Franco, the Spanish civil registry was officially banned from accepting non-Spanish first names. Jordi was rejected. The boy was registered in the Netherlands instead, then brought back to Spain. The name was forbidden on paper. Cruyff used it anyway. He insisted his son be called Jordi, in interviews, on team sheets, in the press.

It is hard to overstate what that did. A foreign superstar, recently arrived, refusing the Franco regime's naming law on behalf of his Catalan newborn. Within a year of that gesture, Franco was dead. Two years after that, the name Jordi was legal again in Spain. The story is the reason a lot of Catalans, in their seventies now, will tell you Cruyff is theirs.

The manager, 1988

He came back in 1988 as manager. The club was a mess. Crowd violence, internal politics, no recent trophies. Cruyff arrived with a single philosophical idea — that football is the simplest game made unnecessarily complicated.

His premise was this. If you have the ball, the other team cannot score. So keep the ball. Move it quickly. Move yourself even faster than the ball moves. Pass it short. Build triangles, always triangles, three players in shifting geometric relation to each other, so there are always two passing options. Use space the way a painter uses canvas. The pitch is wide; make it wider when you have the ball, make it narrower when you don't.

The label *tiki-taka* came later. It was coined by a Spanish broadcaster named Andrés Montes during the 2006 World Cup. Cruyff actually disliked it. He thought it sounded trivial. But it stuck.

Four leagues and Wembley

Cruyff's team won four straight La Liga titles, 1991 through 1994. And in 1992, the Wembley night you just heard about, the European Cup. Before the players walked out of the tunnel, he told them his line. *Salid y disfrutad.* Go out there and enjoy yourselves. He believed football was an entertainment art form. The point was joy, not survival.

When the final whistle blew at Wembley and Barça had won one-nil, Cruyff stood on the touchline with both hands in his trouser pockets, watching his players celebrate. He didn't run on. He didn't cry. He just stood there. He had been waiting nineteen years for that moment.

What he leaves behind

He was sacked in 1996 after a fight with the club president, Josep Lluís Núñez. He never coached anywhere significant again. But everything that happened next at this club — Pep Guardiola, who Cruyff promoted from the youth team to the first team, who later coached the 2009 and 2011 sides in the trophy room behind you; Xavi, Iniesta, Messi, all of whom were trained on Cruyff's ideas as children — all of it traces back to him.

When he died in 2016, the team played their next match wearing white armbands. The fourteenth minute of the next home match — his shirt number — was held in silence. Eighty-five thousand people, standing without a word. For sixty seconds.

Walk past the jersey. There’s an alcove ahead with photographs of an old stone farmhouse on the screens, and touchscreens at child-height. The next room is about a building older than the club.

Track 05 · La Masia

Inside · The 1702 farmhouse and the boys it raised

6 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Move into the La Masia gallery. The centerpiece is a model or illuminated image of the original stone farmhouse, surrounded by touch-screens showing youth academy players. Stand in front of the farmhouse image.

The building you're looking at is older than this club by 197 years. It was built in 1702. A Catalan farmhouse — a *masia* — of stone and tile, with a wide arched gate carved with the coat of arms of Santa Eulàlia, patron saint of Barcelona, and the date of its rebuilding cut into the keystone.

It belonged to a farming family called Planes, who grew olives and grapes on the land. For most of its history, nobody who lived there had heard of football. Then in 1950, the last owner — Francesc Planes Buera — sold the building and the surrounding fields to FC Barcelona. The club needed the land to build Camp Nou.

They didn't demolish the farmhouse. They took it apart, stone by stone, and rebuilt it on the other side of the stadium site. It still stands there, about a hundred metres from where you're standing now, just outside the construction zone, on Avinguda Joan XXIII.

1979 — Oriol Tort's idea, Cruyff's blessing

For the first twenty years after the move, the farmhouse was an architects' office and the club's headquarters. Then, on the 20th of October 1979, it became something else. The club's legendary chief scout, a man named Oriol Tort, had proposed an idea to the then-president Josep Lluís Núñez. The club should bring its most promising young players — boys from outside Barcelona, often from rural Catalonia or from abroad — to live full-time at the club. Eat there. Sleep there. Train there. Cruyff, back in Amsterdam at the time, backed the idea publicly. So the farmhouse was converted into a dormitory.

That building, the converted farmhouse, became known simply as *La Masia.* The farmhouse. The most famous youth academy in football.

What it produced

Look at the touchscreens around the room. They show some of the players who came through. Pep Guardiola, who arrived as a thin thirteen-year-old from a Catalan village in 1984, slept in the farmhouse, and walked out fourteen years later as the captain of Spain. Carles Puyol. Víctor Valdés. Andrés Iniesta, who arrived at twelve from a town in

La Mancha and cried every night for a month from homesickness. Xavi Hernández, the most intelligent passer of his generation. Cesc Fàbregas. Gerard Piqué. Sergio Busquets. And a small Argentinian boy who we'll meet in the next room.

In 2010, the three finalists for the Ballon d'Or — the award for the best player in the world — were Xavi, Iniesta, and Lionel Messi. All three of them had grown up in the same bunk beds, eaten dinner at the same long wooden tables, learned to pass the ball in the same training pitches. No academy in the history of football had produced anything like it. The Spanish national team that won the 2010 World Cup had seven Masia graduates in the starting eleven.

The closing of the farmhouse

On the 30th of June 2011, the farmhouse stopped housing players. The club moved the academy to a new, larger residential complex called the Ciutat Esportiva Joan Gamper, in Sant Joan Despí, on the outskirts of the city. The boys go there now. The 1702 building still stands, restored and quiet, used for ceremonial visits. You can walk past it after this tour.

The next room is darker. There's a circular display in the centre, with golden objects under bright spots. Follow the arrows.

Track 06 · Messi

Inside · The napkin, the 672 goals, and the day he left

9 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Step into the darkened circular Messi room. In the centre, a low curved display holds his Ballons d'Or and Golden Shoes under spotlight. Footage of his goals plays on the walls around you. Stand in the centre and turn slowly.

Stop here. Just look.

Eight golden footballs on rough metal bases. Six Golden Shoes. The trophies of one human career. Lionel Andrés Messi was born on the 24th of June 1987, in Rosario, Argentina, to a steelworker father and a cleaner mother. He started playing for his neighbourhood club, Grandoli, at four. He joined Newell's Old Boys at six. By eleven, he was the best player anyone in Argentina could remember seeing at that age. He was also, by eleven, dangerously small.

The hormone, and the napkin

He had a growth hormone deficiency. His doctors said he needed daily injections of synthetic hormone or he would not grow past four-foot-seven. The injections cost the equivalent of about nine hundred dollars a month, which his family in Rosario could not afford. Newell's wouldn't pay. Argentina's public health system wouldn't cover it for sport. River Plate wouldn't pay. The family was running out of options when a Barça scout named Horacio Gaggioli watched a video of Messi playing a youth tournament.

He invited the family to fly to Barcelona for a trial. In September 2000, the thirteen-year-old Messi played for fifteen minutes against the academy boys. He was so much better than them it was uncomfortable. The club's sporting director, a man named Carles Rexach, asked his assistants for a contract. They couldn't find one. So Rexach took the only paper to hand — a napkin, at a tennis club restaurant called Pompeya — and wrote on it. *In Barcelona, on the 14th of December 2000, in the presence of Messrs. Minguella and Horacio* — then a few words committing the club, in informal Spanish, to sign Messi and pay for his treatment. Rexach signed it. The napkin is in this museum somewhere. Look for it on the way out.

The club paid for the hormone treatment. Messi grew to five-foot-seven. He made his senior debut on the 16th of October 2004, aged seventeen, in a friendly at the Camp Nou you cannot currently see. He stayed for twenty-one years.

672 goals

Look up at the walls. The footage cycling around you is some of what he did in those years.

Six hundred and seventy-two goals for FC Barcelona. The most any player has ever scored for a single club. Eight Ballon d'Or trophies, more than anyone in history. Ten La Liga titles. Seven Copa del Rey trophies. Four Champions Leagues — the 2006, 2009, 2011, and 2015 cups in the trophy room you walked through. The Treble in 2009 — La Liga, Copa del Rey, Champions League — and then the Club World Cup, the European Super Cup, and the Spanish Super Cup the same year. Six trophies in twelve months. No one had ever done that.

But the numbers are not really the point. The point is what it looked like. He played left-footed. He carried the ball at a sprint as if it were attached to him by a string — not lifted, not bouncing, just glued to the outside of his left foot, two centimetres above the grass. He could change direction at full speed without slowing down. He never looked up. He didn't need to. He could feel the geometry of the field in his peripheral vision the way other people feel temperature.

In April 2007, against Getafe, he scored a goal almost identical to Maradona's 1986 World Cup goal against England — he picked up the ball in his own half, beat five players, rounded the goalkeeper, and stroked it in. He was nineteen. In April 2011, in the Champions League semi-final against Real Madrid, he scored a solo goal from the right wing through the entire Madrid defense that ended the tie. There are compilations of these goals that run for hours.

The end

And then, on the 5th of August 2021, the club announced he was leaving.

What happened was this. Barça, under the previous president Josep Maria Bartomeu, had run up about a billion euros of debt. Salary commitments, ageing players on long contracts, bad transfers, the COVID revenue collapse. La Liga had a salary cap. The club had agreed a new contract with Messi, at a reduced salary. He had publicly accepted. Then La Liga did the maths and said the club could not register the deal under the cap. Even at reduced wages. Even with Messi accepting half his old pay.

The club's new president, Joan Laporta, had a choice. Refuse to register him and let him leave on a free transfer. Or sell the club's long-term future to keep him for one more year. He chose the first.

The press conference was on the 8th of August. Messi walked out in a black suit holding a tissue. He sat down and tried to read his statement. He started crying before the first sentence. His wife and three sons were in the front row. He said, in Spanish, that he had

come prepared to sign. That this was not what he had wanted. He cried for most of the press conference. The video is online. It is hard to watch.

He went to Paris Saint-Germain for two seasons, and then to Inter Miami, where he plays now. He won the World Cup with Argentina in December 2022 — the trophy he had spent his entire career trying to win.

The number ten shirt at FC Barcelona has not been formally retired. But no one has been given it since he left. It sits empty. Whether he comes back to play one more match here before he retires — a farewell, a testimonial — is something the city talks about often, and the club and Messi have both implied they want. As of right now, it has not been scheduled.

When you’re ready, follow the flashing floor arrows out of this room. The next chamber is a curved tunnel. Then a much larger space opens up. Stand in the centre.

Track 07 · The 360 Degree Room

Inside · 99,000 voices, in a stadium that no longer exists

6 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Walk into the large oval immersive room. Floor-to-ceiling screens surround you on all sides. A short audiovisual show plays on a loop — about four minutes long. Stand in the centre. The show starts in silence and then erupts. If you're sensitive to strobing light, this is the room to skip; there's a bypass corridor outside.

Hold your ground. The screens around you are about to switch on. When they do, you'll be inside the old Camp Nou, on a match night, in 2010 or thereabouts. The capacity then was 99,354. The roof of the stadium was a thin partial canopy that covered the upper rim of one stand. So the sound, when 99,000 people sang together, didn't echo. It rolled.

What you're about to hear is a recording of the club anthem, the *Cant del Barça*, sung by the home crowd. The anthem was written in 1974 — the year Cruyff signed — for the club's 75th anniversary, with lyrics by the Catalan poets Jaume Picas and Josep Maria Espinas. It is sung in Catalan. The line everyone joins on is the last one. *Tots units fem força. Som la gent blaugrana, tant se val d'on venim, si del sud o del nord.* All united, we make strength. We are the blaugrana people. It doesn't matter where we come from, if from the south or the north.

Why this room exists

The reason this room exists is that the real stadium is sealed. You can't go in. The pitch, the dressing rooms, the dugout — all of it is behind plywood and fencing right now. So the club built a simulator. Floor-to-ceiling screens, surround sound, the visual feeling of standing on the pitch at kickoff. It's a substitute for the thing you came to see. It is also, when the lights come up and the sound rolls, surprisingly close to the real thing.

What you can't simulate is the bass. The old Camp Nou had a sonic footprint that opposing players talked about for decades — a deep, low, rumbling roar that built up under the open sky and pressed down on you from the upper tier. Iker Casillas, who played here many times for Real Madrid, once said it was like being underwater. You could feel the crowd before you could hear them. Not just the volume — the pressure.

The new stadium, when it's finished in 2027, will have a roof. The sound will change. People who know the old building well are bracing for it to be different. Probably sharper. Probably less rolling. We'll find out.

Two minutes of nothing

When the show ends, stay where you are for a moment. There’s usually a two-minute gap before the next loop starts. Take it. You’re standing on the closest thing this complex has, right now, to the inside of the stadium. Look up at the empty ceiling. Try to imagine the bowl outside this building when 99,000 people are in it. Then exit through the door in the far corner marked *Mirador de las Obras* — viewpoint over the works — and climb the stairs.

Track 08 · The Construction Viewpoint

Outside · The bowl, the cranes, and what comes next

7 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Climb the stairs to the engineered wooden viewing deck — the Mirador de las Obras. Lean on the metal railing. Look directly into the open bowl of the stadium. Most of what you can see is the active construction site.

Open your eyes. Take a breath of outside air. You're standing over the thing you came to see.

Down there, in the crater, is where the pitch was. Where Messi scored the impossible solo goal against Real Madrid in 2011. Where Ronaldinho played the no-look pass that the Bernabéu crowd applauded — the rarest honour in football, an opposing crowd standing for an opposing player. Where Maradona played 36 league matches in 1982 and 1983 before hepatitis and a leg-break ended his Barça career. Where Kubála, di Stéfano never played but Messi did, and Cruyff did, and Xavi and Iniesta did. That grass is gone now. The whole base has been excavated.

What you're seeing

Look at the lower bowl, the part closest to where the pitch was. The original 1957 concrete is still there, exposed, with the seats stripped out. That tier was reinforced rather than rebuilt — it was structurally sound. So what you're seeing on the bottom levels is a 68-year-old concrete shell, scrubbed and repaired.

Now look higher. The second tier is a mix — some of it old, some rebuilt. And the very top — the third tier, the upper ring — is new. It's the tier that will lift the final capacity to 105,000 seats. The outer concrete columns rising around the rim — the tall pale grey pillars circling the bowl — those are the structural supports for the new tier and, eventually, for the roof. The roof itself is not yet built. It won't be installed until 2027. When it goes on, it will be the largest stadium roof in the world.

The hard numbers

A few facts to anchor what you're looking at. The main contractor is Limak Holding, based in Ankara, Turkey — chosen on a low bid in late 2022 over Spanish firms, which caused some local complaint. The site runs 24 hours a day. The budget started at 1.5 billion euros and is now reported as higher; the club has had to take on additional financing. The original reopening date of November 2024 has slipped multiple times.

The team returned to a partially reopened stadium on the 22nd of November 2025 — a four-nil win against Athletic Bilbao with about 45,000 in the open tiers. As of March 2026, the capacity has been increased to 62,652 under what's called the Phase 1C licence. The full 105,000 won't be available until after the roof goes on in 2027.

There has also been a labour scandal. In late 2024 and 2025, investigations by the Catalan press exposed that several subcontractors on the site were employing migrant workers — many from Eastern Europe and Turkey — below the legal minimum wage, in unsafe conditions, with withheld passports in some cases. The club has said it is reviewing its subcontracting chain. The story is ongoing. I mention it because the people building the cathedral are doing the actual work, and the new stadium is being built on their hours.

El Clásico, 10th May 2026

Two days ago, as I write this, this stadium hosted its first El Clásico since the rebuild began — Real Madrid versus Barcelona, Sunday the 10th of May 2026. Barça needed a draw to clinch their second straight La Liga title with five matches still to play. They got more than that. The match drew the biggest Clásico crowd at this stadium since the renovation began — the 62,652 of Phase 1C. The rest of the bowl, the part that's under construction in front of you, stayed empty and silent.

That's what you're standing over. A working stadium that is also a working construction site. A 1957 cathedral being rebuilt mid-prayer.

Now step down off the viewing deck and walk into the gallery directly behind you. There's a large architectural model of the finished stadium. That's the next stop.

Track 09 · The Model

Inside · The finished stadium, scaled to your hand

5 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

Step into the architectural gallery. The centerpiece is a large, illuminated 3D scale model of the finished Espai Barça complex. Walk all the way around it; the design is meant to be seen from every side.

Here it is. The whole thing, finished, at one-hundredth scale. The stadium you cannot see from outside because of the cranes.

Walk around the model. Start at the side facing the city — the side closest to the Diagonal, the wide avenue that runs east into central Barcelona. The exterior of the new stadium is open. Not closed. The concourses you can see on the model — the ringed walkways wrapping the bowl on three levels — are open-air. No roof over them, no enclosed tunnels, no dark interior corridors. Fans walk to their seats on balconies that look out over the city. The architects — the Japanese firm Nikken Sekkei working with the Barcelona studio Pascual i Ausió Arquitectes — wanted the building to breathe like a Mediterranean structure. Open courtyards. Sea breeze through the corridors. The opposite of a sealed Northern European football fortress.

The roof

Now look at the roof. The pale curved disk that floats over the bowl on the model. It looks light because it is. It’s a tensioned cable-stayed structure — essentially a giant inverted dish held up by a compression ring of steel running around the top of the third tier. Every seat in the stadium will be covered by it. Currently, nothing is. The old roof covered about two-thirds of the seats; the new one will cover everything.

The top surface of the roof will be tiled with photovoltaic panels — around 30,000 square metres of solar collection. The estimated annual generation is enough to make the complex effectively self-sufficient for electricity, with surplus feeding back into the city grid. There’s also a rainwater capture system that will irrigate the pitch and feed cooling for the concourses. None of this is unique — the Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta and a handful of European arenas have similar features — but at this scale it would be the largest self-sufficient stadium in the world.

The other buildings

Look at the model from above. The main stadium is the centerpiece, but Espai Barça is the whole complex. The lower building to one side is the new Palau Blaugrana — the indoor arena for basketball, handball, and the futsal team, replacing the current 1971 Palau. Construction on that hasn't started yet; this is a future phase. The flat building near the stadium is the new museum — the permanent successor to the temporary one you're standing in. The complex also includes office buildings, a campus zone, and a public park.

The total project, if everything is delivered, makes this corner of Les Corts the largest privately-owned sports complex in Europe. The club's president, Joan Laporta, has called it "the future engine" — the revenue source that pays down the billion euros of debt and keeps the club solvent. Whether that's true depends on a lot of variables. But this is the bet they've made.

Walk out of this gallery through the doors marked Megastore. Down a short corridor. Then through automatic doors into a vast, bright, multi-level shop. The last room of the tour.

Track 10 · Outside Again

Conclusion · The motto returned

5 min

◆ STOP & LOOK

You'll exit through the megastore. Don't stop here for long — it's the busiest part of the complex and not the place to listen to a quiet final track. Walk through it and out the far doors. Stand on the sidewalk outside, in the open air, with the construction site visible over your shoulder. That's where this track ends.

We're almost done. Walk through the megastore. Don't stop. Through the racks of red-and-blue shirts — Yamal's 19, Pedri's 8, the women's team kits at the back — past the cashiers, out the far doors. Step into the Barcelona afternoon.

The names you met

Turn around. Look up at the cranes once more. Then think about who you walked through today.

Joan Gamper, the Swiss accountant who placed an ad in *Los Deportes* in 1899. Josep Sunyol, executed without trial in the Sierra de Guadarrama in August 1936. Johan Cruyff, who named his son in defiance of a regime's naming law and changed how the game is played. Oriol Tort, the scout who convinced the club to bring boys to live in a 1702 farmhouse. Xavi and Iniesta, who slept in those bunk beds. Maradona, who left in a brawl. Ronaldinho, who made the Madrid crowd stand. Lionel Messi, who came as a small boy with a hormone deficiency and left in tears at a press conference. Alexia Putellas and Aitana Bonmatí, who won what the men haven't won lately, and won it three times.

And the people you didn't see. The Limak workers on 24-hour shifts. The migrant subcontractors. The architects. The 90,000 voices that used to sing the Cant del Barça here before the roof comes back on. All of them, in this dust.

The motto, returned

Vázquez Montalbán wrote the cover line in 1972, three years before Franco died, when the club was still the only place a Catalan could stand and sing in their own language. Manuel Vázquez Montalbán was a novelist, a journalist, a Communist activist, and a Barça season-ticket holder. He died in 2003, of a heart attack in the Bangkok airport on his way to a literary festival. He never saw the 2009 sextuple. He never saw Messi at his peak. He never saw the cranes.

The line is on the cover of this script. *El Barça no és un club, és un sentiment.* Barça is not a club, it is a feeling. A feeling held by a Swiss founder and a Catalan martyr and a Dutch genius and an Argentine prodigy, and now held by ten million people who have never set foot in Catalonia. The motto on the wall is older than that. *Més que un club.* More than a club.

Today you stood in front of a building that is, literally, in the middle of becoming itself. A stadium with no roof, a museum in a former ice rink, a 360-degree room substituting for a pitch you cannot enter. It is unfinished. It will be unfinished through 2027. Most of what you saw today will not exist in this form a year from now. The cranes will be gone. The viewing deck will be torn down. The temporary museum will be replaced by the permanent one in the model you just looked at. You happened to walk through the only moment when this place looks like this.

Where to go next

If you have time today, three short walks. Five minutes east on Avinguda Joan XXIII, you can find the old Masia farmhouse — the 1702 stone building, restored, quiet, still standing. Twenty minutes by metro from here, the Joan Cruyff Stadium in Sant Joan Despí — the smaller ground where the Barça Femí play their home Champions League matches, and where the men sometimes play during big stadium renovations. Forty-five minutes north by train, the town of Vic — birthplace of neither anyone famous nor any decisive moment in football history, but the most beautiful market square in Catalonia. Skip it and have a *cafè amb llet* on the Diagonal instead, watching the cranes from a sidewalk café. That works too.

Farewell

Thank you for walking Camp Nou with me. Or what is left of it. Or what is rising in its place. *El Barça no és un club, és un sentiment.* Barça is not a club, it is a feeling. *Visca el Barça. Visca Catalunya.* Fins aviat.